Teacher and cover plan — The local canvas: architectural line and form

Pathway: TRACK · Week 1 Part 2 · Big question: How can we use structural line, negative space, and surface frottage to record built architecture?

Learning goals and studio kit

• Analyse how girders, arches, and trusses lock together in engineered structures.

• Use negative-space observation to draw the open shapes between structural beams accurately.

• Layer directional line weights over textured surface studies to show depth.

Studio kit: Architectural structure reference cards, textured relief plates, 2B/4B pencils, fineliners, wide graphite sticks, cartridge paper

Arrival and starter

Arrival: Look at the bridge truss photo card. Instead of looking at the metal bars, look at the sky gaps between them. What shapes are the gaps?

Starter question: Why do architectural illustrators often draw the empty 'negative space' shapes between beams first?

Teacher model (I do)

Step 1: Lay down a subtle texture ground: I take a light graphite rubbing from a mesh and corrugated plate across two zones of my sheet.

Step 2: Map the outer envelope and negative spaces: I sketch the overall bounding box, then draw the triangle and arch sky gaps inside.

Step 3: Build structural line weight: I press firmly with a 4B pencil and fineliner on the front girders so they step forward in space.

Practice routes (Supported / Independent / Aspire)

Supported: Texture ground with accurate negative-space truss drawing and varied line weight.

Independent: Resolved architectural drawing over textured ground with three technical annotations.

Aspire: Two-plane architectural study with tonal depth, chalk highlights, and spatial notes.

TA and cover notes

TA focus: Provide clear acetate grids that pupils can lay over architectural reference photos to spot the negative-space triangles.

Staff prep: Staff preparation only: review a short demonstration on using negative-space triangles and varied line weight to draw engineered trusses.